

Taper Editor Report - NYC Marathon Plan

The Taper Editor — report on your NYC Marathon plan

I read your whole plan. Here's what I found, most important first.

Your final week passes the one check I refuse to compromise on. Three things are on the record, each with your name on it: this race is the goal (the plan declares it; you confirmed it); your easy pace is about a 12-minute mile (you stated it — I never guess a pace); and race-week Wednesday's "optional easy swim/rest" is a rest, per your call. With those recorded, the machine count says: your race week averages about 14 minutes of training a day against about 34 a day across the fourteen weeks before it, and race week's biggest session (36 minutes) is a fraction of your biggest training day (four hours — the 20-miler). The plan winds down hard before November 1. That's called a **taper** — reducing training in the last stretch so you arrive at the start rested — and yours passes on both counts. A pass is not a prescription. Three flags below are yours to weigh; I state each once.

Also on the record, as checks performed: all 55 dated sessions in your plan sit on the weekday the plan claims, and every weekly mileage target I could recompute adds up exactly from its listed runs — ten out of ten.

1. Two weeks of your plan aren't on the calendar at all.

Your plan says: "Week 4: Aug 10-16 — 15-18 mi — 4 easy; 4 easy; 3 easy; 4-6 easy" — and Week 5 reads the same way. Runs with mileage, but no days attached.

The problem: *Calendar and arithmetic integrity* — every session in a plan should sit on a date, and every amount should be computable. For your travel weeks, the plan lists runs that exist on no particular day, plus ranges ("4-6 easy," "bike 45-75 min") that aren't numbers until you pick one. Fair is fair: dateless flexibility during travel is sensible coaching, not a defect. But it means my math — including the wind-down I just verified — sees those two weeks as lighter than they may actually be.

What it costs you: the plan warns you not to cram mileage around travel, but with no dates and no fixed amounts, neither you nor the plan can later check whether Weeks 4-5 stayed inside their own target. A week that can't be added up can't be kept honest.

Your call: when you're on the road, who decides what "4-6 easy" turns into that day — a number you set in advance, or the mood?

2. The bike has a speed limit with no ticket.

Your plan says: “As long runs reach 16, 18, and 20 miles, reduce cycling intensity. A hard two-hour bike ride is not a recovery day simply because it is not running.”

The problem: *Missing ceiling* — every stated limit needs a defined response for when it’s broken. Credit first: this plan’s running limits genuinely have teeth (“treat weekly mileage as a ceiling, not a contract,” drop the Saturday run before the long run, never cram missed miles). But the cycling limit is advice without a consequence: if you do hammer a two-hour ride the day before your 18-miler, the plan never says what changes — the long run arrives on schedule as if nothing happened.

What it costs you: in your peak month, your legs’ biggest threat isn’t the running the plan counts — it’s the riding it doesn’t. A limit with no response has silently decided the answer is “nothing,” and you’d find that out at mile 14 of a 16-mile Sunday.

Your call: if a ride goes hard in October, what changes about that weekend’s long run — and says who?

3. The plan grades its own travel accommodation.

Your plan says: “The August 10-26 restriction is manageable and should not be offset by cramming extra-long runs before or immediately after travel.”

The problem: *Self-certification* — a plan’s claims about its own adequacy are claims, not facts. “Manageable” is the plan’s own grade for its own solution — and notice it’s grading exactly the two weeks that, per Finding 1, sit on no dates and no fixed amounts. The one stretch the plan calls manageable is the one stretch the math can’t see.

What it costs you: probably little — the advice attached to the claim (don’t cram) is sound. But if “manageable” made you stop thinking about August, it did a reviewer’s job without a reviewer’s work. Whether those weeks were actually manageable will be decided by your legs on August 30, not by that sentence.

Your call: what would “Weeks 4-5 went fine” actually look like, in numbers you could check on August 27?

Where this leaves you

The race-week check is passed and all three of your declarations are on the record. The three flags above are warnings, not fails — you may accept any of them; I’ve said each once and won’t nag. This report points at the plan; it doesn’t rewrite it, and it doesn’t prescribe your training — that stays between you and your plan. See you in November — the call on every finding is yours.